Lesson 3 — The Night the Network Failed

Level: A2 (third step)

Theme: Computing and student life: files, servers and backups

Time: 6 sessions, 45–55 minutes each

Skills: Listening → Reading → Vocabulary → Grammar → Comprehension → Speaking → Writing

New in this lesson: the past continuous, the weak sounds of was and were, a longer passage of 320 words, and one new question type: purpose of a paragraph

01 · Passage — The Night the Network Failed

> How to do the listening. Same rule as Lessons 1 and 2: the student listens twice with no text, then reads. Audio files: `01-passage.mp3` first, then the other parts in order. Part `05-weak-forms.mp3` is new — the weak sounds of was and were.

1.1 Before listening (2 minutes, Arabic is fine here)

1. Where do you keep the work you are doing now?
2. What do you do when the electricity stops in the middle of your work?
3. How many copies of your most important file do you have?

1.4 Now read the passage

Passage: The Night the Network Failed (320 words)

Last March, Omar was finishing his final project at the computer centre. He was studying software engineering, and the project was the most important work of his year. The college wanted it on Friday morning.

[A] On Tuesday evening, he was sitting at his usual desk. The room was quiet. Three other students were working near the window, and the lights were low. Omar was uploading his files to the college server when the screen stopped moving.

At first he was not worried. The internet in the building was often slow, so he waited. He checked the cable. He restarted the browser. Nothing changed on the screen. The upload was stuck at sixty per cent.

[B] Then the lights went out. The electricity was off, and the room was completely dark. The other students were laughing, because this happened almost every week. Omar was not laughing. His computer turned off while it was writing to the server, and he did not know which files arrived and which did not.

When the power came back, twenty minutes later, he opened his folder again. The file was there, but it was broken. The computer could not open it. He tried it again, and then he tried it on another machine. Three months of work were inside that file.

[C] Then he remembered something his teacher said in the first week: "Save often, and save in two places." He opened his email. While he was uploading the file that evening, he also sent a copy to himself — not because he was careful, but because he wanted to read it at home.

The copy was from Sunday. It was two days old.

[D] Omar finished the project that night. He slept for four hours. In the morning, before his class, he bought a small USB drive. Now, when he is working on something important, he saves it in three places: the computer, his email, and the drive.

1.5 Read aloud

Read the passage aloud once and record it. Compare it with your Lesson 2 recording: are you stopping less often?

02 · Listening questions

1.2 Listening — first time (no text)

L1. Who is the story about, and what was he studying?

L2. What was he doing when the screen stopped moving?

L3. What saved his work in the end?

L4. How old was the copy he found?

1.3 Listening — second time (no text)

Write four verbs in the past continuous that you heard (was or were + -ing). Then write one word you heard but did not understand.

03 · Vocabulary and Lesson 1 recall

2.1 Key words

#	WORD	TYPE	SIMPLE MEANING	ARABIC	EXAMPLE
1	server	noun	a big computer that keeps files for many people	خادم	He was uploading his files to the college server.
2	upload	verb	to send a file from your computer to the internet	يرفع	The upload was stuck at sixty per cent.
3	project	noun	a large piece of work you do over a long time	مشروع	It was the most important project of his year.
4	software	noun	the programs that run on a computer	برمجيات	He was studying software engineering.
5	screen	noun	the part of a computer you look at	شاشة	The screen stopped moving.
6	restart	verb	to start something again	يعيد التشغيل	He restarted the browser.
7	browser	noun	the program you use to open websites	متصفح	He restarted the browser.
8	stuck	adjective	not able to move	عالق	The upload was stuck.
9	broken	adjective	damaged, and not working	تالف	The file was there, but it was broken.
10	cable	noun	the wire that joins two machines	كابل	He checked the cable.
11	version	noun	one form of something that changes over time	إصدار	It was not the newest version.
12	save	verb	to keep your work on a computer	يحفظ	Save often, and save in two places.
13	per cent	noun	one part in every hundred	بالمئة	The upload was stuck at sixty per cent.
14	careful	adjective	giving attention so nothing goes wrong	حَذِر	Not because he was careful.

2.2 Synonyms and opposites

WORD	SYNONYM	OPPOSITE
upload	send up	download
broken	damaged	working / fine
stuck	not moving	moving / free
careful	giving attention	careless

WORD	SYNONYM	OPPOSITE
quiet	silent	noisy / loud
finish	complete	start / begin
dark	with no light	bright / light
often	many times	never / rarely

2.3 Expressions to learn

EXPRESSION	WHAT IT REALLY MEANS
at first	in the beginning, before things changed
per cent	in every hundred (sixty per cent = 60 in every 100)
the power came back	the electricity returned
save in two places	keep two copies, in different places
three months of work	work that took three months
in the middle of	while something was still happening
not because … but because	the real reason is the second one

2.4 Vocabulary practice

A. Write the opposite:

1. upload → _____
2. careful → _____
3. broken → _____
4. noisy → _____
5. finish → _____

B. Which word is different? Say why:

1. server — browser — software — evening
2. screen — cable — drive — project
3. stuck — broken — damaged — careful

C. Say it in your own words:

1. What is a server?
2. What does stuck mean?

04 · Grammar — the past continuous

We use the past continuous for an action that was in the middle of happening in the past: At eight o'clock, Omar was uploading his files.

3.1 How we make it

was / were + verb -ing

PERSON	PAST CONTINUOUS
I / he / she / it	was working
you / we / they	were working

3.2 What we use it for

An action in the middle of happening: At eight o'clock he was uploading his files.

A long action stopped by a short one: He was uploading his files when the screen stopped.

Two long actions at the same time: While* the students were laughing, Omar was looking* at his screen.

The background of a story: The room was quiet. Three students were working near the window.

3.4 Past simple or past continuous?

PAST SIMPLE — THE SHORT, FINISHED ACTION	PAST CONTINUOUS — THE LONGER ACTION AROUND IT
The screen stopped.	He was uploading his files.
The lights went out.	The students were working.
The computer turned off.	It was writing to the server.

The rule to remember: when + past simple, while + past continuous.

3.5 Negative and question

	FORM	EXAMPLE
Negative	was not / were not + -ing	Omar was not laughing.
Question	Was / Were + person + -ing	Were the students laughing?

3.6 Grammar practice

A. Put the verb in the past continuous:

1. At eight o'clock, Omar _____ (sit) at his usual desk.
2. Three students _____ (work) near the window.
3. The computer turned off while it _____ (write) to the server.

4. _____ the students _____ (laugh)?
5. Omar _____ (not laugh).

B. Choose the past simple or the past continuous:

1. He (uploaded / was uploading) his files when the screen (stopped / was stopping).
2. While the power (was / was being) off, the students (talked / were talking).
3. He (found / was finding) the email while he (looked / was looking) for the file.

05 · The sounds of was and were

3.3 The two sounds of was and were (listen to `05-weak-forms.mp3`)

In a sentence, was and were are almost always weak — short and quiet. They are strong only at the end of a sentence, or when we want to insist that something is true.

WORD	WEAK (NORMAL, INSIDE A SENTENCE)	STRONG (AT THE END, OR TO INSIST)
was	/wəz/	/wɒz/
were	/wə/	/wɜː/

WEAK	STRONG
He was working at his desk.	Yes, he was.
The room was quiet.	It was.
Three students were working near the window.	Yes, they were.
The lights were low.	They were.

In the audio you hear each pair twice, then a short test: say whether the was or were you hear is weak or strong, then listen to the answer.

06 · Comprehension — TOEFL question types

Part A — Multiple choice

1. (Factual) What was Omar studying?

   A. Design.
   B. Software engineering.
   C. Electricity.
   D. The passage does not say.

2. (Factual) What was Omar doing when the screen stopped moving?

   A. He was reading his email.
   B. He was uploading his files to the college server.
   C. He was restarting the browser.
   D. He was talking to the other students.

3. (Negative factual) According to the passage, Omar did all of the following EXCEPT

   A. check the cable.
   B. restart the browser.
   C. call his teacher.
   D. open his email.

4. (Vocabulary in context) The word "stuck" in the passage is closest in meaning to

   A. not moving.
   B. very fast.
   C. finished.
   D. broken into pieces.

5. (Reference) In the sentence, the file was there, but it was broken, the word "it" refers to

   A. the folder.
   B. the server.
   C. the file.
   D. the computer.

6. (Inference) It can be inferred from the passage that

   A. Omar sent the copy to himself because he was afraid of losing the file.
   B. Omar lost three months of work.
   C. power cuts were common in that building.
   D. the other students lost their work too.

7. (Sentence insertion) Look at the four letters [A] [B] [C] [D] in the passage. Where would this sentence best fit?

> It was not the newest version, but it opened without a problem.

- A. At [A]
- B. At [B]
- C. At [C]
- D. At [D]

8. (Purpose of a paragraph — NEW) Why does the writer mention what Omar's teacher said in the first week?

A. To show that Omar was a careful student.
B. To explain how Omar found a second copy of his work.
C. To criticise the college for its electricity.
D. To show that the teacher was angry with Omar.

Part C — Fill in the blanks

Use these words. There are two extra words you will not need.

> server · stuck · broken · cable · version · save · per cent · careful · browser · project

1. Omar was finishing his final _____ at the computer centre.
2. He was uploading his files to the college _____.
3. The upload was _____ at sixty _____.
4. He checked the _____ and restarted the _____.
5. The file was there, but it was _____.
6. His teacher said: "_____ often, and save in two places."

Part D — Summary

Write the story in two sentences only. Use the past continuous once.

> Sentence 1 — what went wrong: _____ Sentence 2 — what saved his work: _____

07 · True / false

Part B — True / False

Write T or F. If it is false, write the correct sentence.

1. Omar was studying design. ____
2. The upload stopped at sixty per cent. ____
3. Omar was laughing with the other students. ____
4. The power came back after twenty minutes. ____
5. The copy in his email was from Tuesday. ____
6. Omar bought a USB drive the next morning. ____

08 · Speaking

5.1 Speaking (record each answer, 45 seconds)

1. Tell the story of Omar in your own words. Use while, when, at first, and after that.
2. Describe a time when you were working and something stopped you. What were you doing? What happened?
3. Where do you save your most important files now? Is that enough? Why?

Useful sentence starters:

I was working on ____ when ____.

While I was ____, the ____ stopped.

At first I thought ____.

After that, I started to ____.

I save my files on ____, because ____.

09 · Writing — The Day Something Stopped My Work

5.2 Writing — "The Day Something Stopped My Work" (10–12 sentences)

Model answer (copy the shape, change the words):

> Last year, I was writing a long report for my course. I was working at home in the evening, and the room was quiet. While I was typing, the electricity stopped. My laptop had no battery, so the screen went dark. At first I was angry, because I did not save the file. I waited for two hours. When the power came back, I opened the file again. The computer showed an old version from the morning. I lost three hours of work. Now I save my work every ten minutes, and I keep a copy on a USB drive. It is a small habit, but it helps.

Checklist before you send it:

- [ ] I used the past continuous for the long action (I was writing, while I was typing).
- [ ] I used the past simple for the short action that stopped it (the electricity stopped).
- [ ] I used when with the past simple and while with the past continuous.
- [ ] I used at least 5 new words from Session 2.
- [ ] I used at least 2 words from Lesson 1 or Lesson 2.
- [ ] Capital letters and full stops are correct.
- [ ] My text has 10–12 sentences.

10 · Review

6.1 Listen again (no text)

1. Name three things Omar did when the screen stopped moving.
2. Why did he have a second copy of his file?

6.2 Mini-quiz (12 marks)

1. The past continuous of work, for he, is _____
2. The past continuous of laugh, for they, is _____
3. We use ____ with the past simple and ____ with the past continuous. (when / while) _____
4. The opposite of upload is _____
5. The opposite of careful is _____
6. A big computer that keeps files for many people is a _____
7. The program you use to open websites is a _____
8. Not able to move = _____
9. Write a sentence with while and the past continuous.
10. Write a negative sentence in the past continuous.
11. Write one sentence with version.
12. Tell the story of the passage in two sentences, from memory.

6.3 Lesson 3 self-report

QUESTION	ANSWER
Minutes studied this week	
Hardest part (listening / reading / vocabulary / grammar / speaking / writing)	
Past-continuous sentences I can now make without thinking	
Words from Lesson 1 I have forgotten	
One thing I want to repeat next week	

11 · Answer key and teacher notes

Listening: L1 — Omar, software engineering · L2 — uploading his files to the college server · L3 — a copy he had sent to his own email · L4 — two days old (from Sunday)

Part A (MCQ): 1-B · 2-B · 3-C · 4-A · 5-C · 6-C · 7-D · 8-B

Why 7 is [D]: the sentence says the copy opened, so it can only follow "The copy was from Sunday. It was two days old." At [C]** it would contradict the broken file described just before it.

Why 8 is [B]**: the teacher's words are what make Omar think of his email, so that paragraph exists to explain how he found the second copy — not to describe Omar, and not to blame the college.

Part B (True/False):

1. F — He was studying software engineering.
2. T
3. F — Omar was not laughing.
4. T
5. F — It was from Sunday.
6. T

Part C (Fill in the blanks): 1. project · 2. server · 3. stuck, per cent · 4. cable, browser · 5. broken · 6. Save (Extra words: version, careful)

2.4 A (Opposites): 1. download · 2. careless · 3. working / fine · 4. quiet / silent · 5. start / begin

2.4 B (Odd one out): 1. evening (the others are computer words) · 2. project (the others are things you can touch) · 3. careful (the others mean damaged or not moving)

3.6 A (Past continuous): 1. was sitting · 2. were working · 3. was writing · 4. Were … laughing · 5. was not laughing 3.6 B (Simple or continuous): 1. was uploading, stopped · 2. was, were talking · 3. found, was looking

Mini-quiz: 1. was working · 2. were laughing · 3. when, while · 4. download · 5. careless · 6. server · 7. browser · 8. stuck · 9–12. teacher judgement

Teacher Notes

What changed from Lesson 2. The passage grew from 244 to 320 words, the past continuous joins the past simple, and an eighth question type — purpose of a paragraph — joins sentence insertion. The pronunciation slot moves from the three sounds of -ed to the weak forms of was and were. The order of the sessions, the self-report and the six original TOEFL question types are deliberately unchanged, so only one thing is new at a time.

The one real difficulty. Not the form — was + -ing is easy to build — but knowing when to choose it. Arabic marks the progressive past differently, so the student will reach for the past simple everywhere and say while I worked, the power stopped. Drill the pair in 3.4 until while automatically pulls -ing behind it.

Why this story. The vocabulary is the vocabulary of her actual working life: server, upload, browser, version, save. She is about to carry application files, scans and transcripts between machines, and the passage teaches that problem while teaching the tense. It is also the third story in a row in which the lesson is keep a second copy — that repetition is intentional.

Success criteria for Lesson 3. The student should be able to:

- answer L1–L4 correctly on the second hearing;
- retell the story in 5–6 sentences using at least two past-continuous verbs;
- choose correctly between past simple and past continuous in 3.6 B;
- hear the difference between weak and strong was;
- use 10 of the 14 key words in her own sentence;
- write 10 sentences about a personal past event with fewer than 4 tense errors.

If it is too easy: Lesson 4 goes to 400 words, adds the present perfect (I have saved it), and the MCQ set adds a rhetorical-purpose question about the whole passage. If it is too hard: keep the same passage for a second week, drop question 8, and drill only 3.1 and 3.4.

A note on spaced recall. `03-vocabulary.mp3` ends with five Lesson 1 words — check, centre, tool, slow, wake up — which are the five she has not heard since Lesson 1, because Lesson 2 recalled the other five. Lesson 2's own words come back in Lesson 4. Keep that two-lesson gap: it is the gap, not the repetition, that moves a word into long-term memory.